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To loop through a directory in Bash, **do not use** `ls`. Parsing `ls` breaks if filenames contain spaces or newlines. Instead, **use native Bash globbing** (`*`), which safely handles all special characters. 🍷 Reddit +4

Safe Approach: Using Native Globbing (Recommended)

This loop targets files safely in the current working directory. 🌐 DigitalOcean +1

bash

```
for file in *; do
    echo "Processing: $file"
done
```

Use code with caution.



Specific Target Examples

- **Specify a target directory:**

bash

```
for file in /path/to/directory/*; do
    echo "$file"
done
```

Use code with caution.



- **Target specific file types** (e.g., `.txt` files):

bash

```
for file in *.txt; do
    echo "$file"
done
```

Use code with caution.



- **Loop through directories only:**

bash

```
for dir in */; do
    echo "Directory: $dir"
done
```

Use code with caution.

- **Include hidden files** (files starting with a dot):

Run `shopt -s dotglob` in your terminal before executing your loop. [Unix & Linux Stack Exch... +5](#)

Why Avoid `ls` ?

When you write `for file in $(ls)`, Bash splits the output by whitespace. If you have a file named `My Report.pdf`, the loop will treat it as two separate files: `My` and `Report.pdf`. Globbing (`*`) preserves the entire filename as a single item. [Unix & Linux Stack Exch... +4](#)

If you need to find files **recursively** down through subdirectories, let me know if you would prefer a example using the **find command** or enabling Bash's built-in **globstar option**. [Stack Overflow +4](#)

 10 sites

bash - Loop through directory with space in the name

Jul 13, 2020 — 1 Answer * Note how I use for dir in /dir1/dir2/TopLevel/*/ and not just for dir in /dir1/dir2/TopLevel/* . This is to only iterat...



[Unix & Linux Stack Exchange](#)

for loop over directory content with ls, files with spaces in name

Oct 25, 2020 — Here's some information about for loops over directory content with ls: * **Parsing the output of ls is not recommended** * **You ...

 Reddit

How do I loop through only directories in bash?

Aug 14, 2013 — This code will loop through all files in the current directory, check if f is a



directory, then echo f if the condition returns tr...



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10+ answers · 16 years ago

bash - How can I loop over directories in Linux?

I am writing a script in Bash on Linux and need to go through all subdirectory names in a given directory. How can I loop through these directories (and ...

[10 answers](#) · Top answer: All answers so far use find, so here's one with just the shell. No need for ext...

[bash - Looping through all files in a directory - Stack ...](#) 6 answers Dec 14, 2011

[How to loop over files in directory and change path ...](#) 6 answers Dec 27, 2013

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Super User

<https://superuser.com> › questions › looping-through-ls-...

looping through `ls` results in bash shell script

Aug 28, 2009 — Does any one have a template shell script for doing something with ls for a list of directory names and looping through each one and doing something? ...

[9 answers](#) · Top answer: Edited not to use ls where a glob would do, as @shawn-j-goff and others sug...

[Loop through directories and subdirectories in bash](#) 3 answers Sep 13, 2018

[Bash script iterate through directory and delete zip file](#) 1 answer Jul 2, 2025

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Unix & Linux Stack Exchange

<https://unix.stackexchange.com> › questions › how-do-i-...

How do I loop through only directories in bash?

Aug 14, 2013 — I have a folder with some directories and some files (some are hidden, beginning with

Aug 14, 2013 — I have a folder with some directories and some files (some are hidden, beginning with dot). for d in *; do echo \$d done will loop through all files ...

[14 answers](#) · 140 votes: You can test with -d: for f in *; do if [-d "\$f"]; then # \$f is a directory fi done Thi...

[shell script - Loop through a folder and list files](#) 4 answers Apr 6, 2017

[shell script - Bash for loop over ls splits line at ...](#) 1 answer Oct 27, 2020

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Metagenomics wiki

<https://www.metagenomics.wiki> › tools › shell-loop

Loop over list of files

Shell **loop through** files - Examples Run a command on each file do something (echo) with all .txt files
for f in *.txt; do echo \${f}; done;



Reddit · r/bash

8 comments · 5 years ago

for loop over directory content with ls, files with spaces in ...

Im trying to clear up space on my MacBook by backing up all the files under ~/Documents then deleting. I ran into an error just running rsync.

[r/bash on Reddit: How to loop through directories where ...](#) 17 posts Jul 29, 2022

[\[Absolute Beginner\] Looping through folders in a directory](#) 10 posts Jun 24, 2021

[More results from www.reddit.com](#)



DigitalOcean

<https://www.digitalocean.com> › community › tutorials

How To Loop Through Files in a Directory

Aug 19, 2020 — In this tutorial you'll **iterate over** files and apply commands using either the **Bash** or zsh shells. ... Now use the **ls** command to display each file ...



warp.dev

<https://www.warp.dev> › Terminus by Warp › Bash

How To Loop Through Files in a Directory in Bash - Warp

May 16, 2024 — To create a Bash script that loops through files in a specified directory and prints their path, you can start by **creating a new file using the touch command**.

[The short answer](#)

[Including and excluding files](#)

[Looping through files recursively](#)



Quora

4 answers · 6 years ago

How to loop through “ls” results in bash shell script ...

How do you loop through “ls” results in bash shell script (bash, shell, shell script, admin)?

[4 answers](#)

The answer: This is a good example of how the right answer really depends on a more specific

4 answers · Top answer: This is a good example of how the right answer really depends on a more reth...



YouTube · The Computer Oracle

7 views · 3 years ago

looping through `ls` results in bash shell script



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Shell script to loop through files in a directory and subdirectories

Bash **for** loop

Loop through all files in a directory Python

Bash loop **over files matching pattern**

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